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Hiring Committee
San Diego Association of Governments (SANDAG)
1011 Union Street
San Diego, CA 92101

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am writing to express my interest in the Economic Research Analyst (Associate/Senior) position in the Data Science Department at the San Diego Association of Governments (SANDAG). I am a Ph.D. candidate in the Department of Economics at Johns Hopkins University (advisors: Christopher D. Carroll, Nicholas W. Papageorge, and Stelios Fourakis), and I expect to receive my degree in May 2026. My primary areas of specialization are macroeconomic modeling, wealth and income dynamics, and computational economics.

My research agenda focuses on the ability of macroeconomic models to generate empirically realistic distributions of wealth and income over the life cycle. A key driver of wealth accumulation is the rate of return earned on assets, and understanding this relationship requires robust econometric analysis and careful treatment of heterogeneity in microdata. These topics connect closely to SANDAG's emphasis on data-driven economic analysis, forecasting, and model-based evaluation of regional trends and policy scenarios.

In my job market paper, I calibrate a life-cycle model to match wealth moments from the Survey of Consumer Finances by allowing households to differ in their portfolio returns. This modeling approach mirrors the empirical modeling challenges SANDAG faces when forecasting household behavior and regional aggregates. In a related project using the Health and Retirement Study, I examine the link between trust and returns to wealth. I replicate the known hump-shaped relationship between trust and income and show that a similar relationship holds for portfolio returns. I also characterize the distribution of the persistent component of returns to net worth—findings that inform how long-term, household-level heterogeneity translates into regional economic patterns.

I am particularly drawn to this position because it integrates applied econometric modeling, forecasting, and benefit–cost analysis to inform infrastructure, fiscal, and planning decisions for the San Diego region. My training in both structural modeling and empirical microeconometrics equips me to contribute to all four core functions of SANDAG's Economics team: (i) developing and maintaining econometric forecasting models; (ii) conducting benefit–cost and policy analyses; (iii) performing financial and economic forecasting; and (iv) producing accessible reports and data visualizations for technical and nontechnical audiences.

I believe I would be a strong fit for SANDAG's Data Science Department because:

1. My research and programming experience (Python, R, and Stata) has prepared me to build and maintain econometric and forecasting models with transparency and replicability.

2. I have substantial experience working with large-scale survey microdata (SCF, HRS, PSID), consistent with the Department's emphasis on data from BLS, BEA, and Census.
3. My empirical and computational background aligns with SANDAG's focus on producing actionable insights that connect economic trends, transportation infrastructure, and regional development.

I am inspired by SANDAG's mission to use data science and applied economics to support informed policy and investment decisions in the San Diego region. I would welcome the opportunity to contribute my quantitative and modeling expertise to this work and to help strengthen the region's economic and infrastructure planning capacity.

Thank you for considering my application.

Sincerely,

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